

Topic E2: Mass Media, Popular Culture and Social Change in Britain since 1945

the period since the end of the Second World War and, specifically, on the roles of the mass media and of popular culture in influencing this overall change. Questions will not be set which focus on the specified forms of mass media and popular culture themselves but students should have knowledge and understanding of their impact and wider social significance. A topic of this nature relies on the study of particular cases in the context of wider trends. Students will be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification bullet points by the deployment of relevant exemplification and will be given credit for making reference to relevant case studies in addition to those specifically identified below. Some questions may incorporate source material relating to cases other than those specified below. Such questions will not require students to have knowledge of the particular example but to appreciate the trend or issue it exemplifies.

Collectively, the four content bullet points offer a framework for understanding the relationship between the mass media and changes in British society in the period. Students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a consideration of the influence of changes in media and communications on the family since 1945 could discuss their influence on attitudes to and within families (bullet point 1), on family leisure pursuits (bullet points 3 and 4), and on family working patterns (bullet point 4).

The first bullet point relates to the role of newspapers, radio, cinema and television in society since 1945. Students should appreciate the media's growing significance in the period as the means of communications changed and improved. The phrase 'the relationship between mass media and changes in attitudes and values in British society' relates to the role of mass media in influencing social and cultural attitudes and opinions and the interaction between the media and prevailing attitudes in society. How far did the media lead or merely reflect the process of change? This can be explored and illustrated through studies of attitudes to: consumerism, class, gender roles, the family, and the position of ethnic minorities in British society.

The second bullet point relates to the impact of mass media on the specified aspects of British society. Students should be aware of the growth in challenges to authority and authority figures and have sufficient knowledge and understanding of relevant case studies to illustrate the role of the mass media in changing attitudes to Government and the monarchy in the period. Specifically they should have knowledge of the media's treatment of Diana, Princess of Wales, in the years 1981-97 and the implications of this treatment in raising issues relating to privacy and celebrity and in changing attitudes to, and the role and status of, the monarchy itself. The phrase 'investigative journalism and its consequences' relates to the role of journalists in uncovering controversial developments and the campaigning role of journalists in respect of the actions of Government. Specifically, students should have knowledge and understanding of the media's handling of the cases of Clive Ponting and the sinking of the Belgrano 1982-85 and Dr David Kelly and the Iraq dossier in 2003. Students should also appreciate the role of satire — the ways in which mass media represented leaders in society and attempted to call them to account.

The third bullet point relates to popular and youth culture from the mid-1950s. Students should appreciate the growing importance of popular music and have made a case study of the impact of the Beatles in the 1960s. They should understand the ways in which popular music has challenged existing authority and appreciate the growing influence of young people in British social and cultural life. Students should be aware of the growing importance of, and influence in, British cultural and social life of film and television programmes produced in the USA. They should also appreciate the importance of television 'soap operas' and developments in so-called 'reality television' and 'celebrity culture': the ways in which soap operas influenced and reflected contemporary social issues and debates, and the reasons why, and how, celebrities were considered important in contemporary society. The phrase 'the relationship between elite and popular culture' in the specification relates to the extent to which both elite and popular culture were coming together and to debates about what 'culture' signified in a modern, mass society.

The fourth bullet point relates to the impact of the internet and the worldwide web. The phrase 'changing relationship between individuals and society' relates specifically to the extent to which changes in information technology and new forms of communication affected patterns of work and leisure and influenced the roles of individuals in society. Students should appreciate the impact of the internet on the ways in which people in Britain interacted and on the speed with which news and views could be communicated both via television and radio and on the web itself, and the implications of this for government and authority and the individual citizen.